

Totality as a Category

An Epistemological Investigation

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Chapter I

The Position of the Doctrine of Categories in Philosophy

1. Categories are fundamental concepts which are contained in the presuppositions on which all scientific research rests, and which can be exhibited by analysis of those presuppositions. But for a full elucidation of their nature it is not enough to start out from the science existing at a given time. It must also be shown how they have worked their way forward through the history of science, — how they arise as forms of thought-work, — and how they can disappear again when they are no longer expressions of labouring thought. And from such a historical consideration one must go back again to a psychological investigation of the development of thinking in ordinary human conscious life, of which scientific thinking is a peculiar formation conditioned by determinate tasks. The fundamental concepts with which science works must be psychologically possible, and their first origin must be findable in involuntary thought-life. The difference between the psychological and the epistemological consideration of the categories consists in this, that the former finds possibility for unscientific as well as for scientific thinking, whereas the latter shows that under certain given conditions there is only one single narrow road to understanding. Of our thoughts it holds that many are called, few chosen, — indeed, we must add as psychologists, that many are uncalled.

In epistemological works one will find different weight laid on fundamental concepts and on fundamental propositions. Some epistemologists keep solely to the fundamental propositions, the propositions on which scientific grounding rests. And since propositions

that are presuppositions for all grounding naturally cannot themselves be grounded, the fundamental propositions are often presented as resting on a choice, a leap, an act which in and for itself might just as well have fallen out in quite another direction. The first principles of science are, on this conception, not themselves an object for science. Yet it is for the most part conceded by those who hold this conception that the choice is bound within a certain circle of possibilities, and that this circle of possibilities is given with the nature of human thinking, such as this once and for all is constituted. It is psychology's task to investigate this factual constitution, and the question then presents itself how the different standpoints from which epistemology and psychology assess human cognition stand to one another. But even before we take up this question it will be clear that there is such a reciprocal relation between fundamental concepts and fundamental propositions, as in general between concepts and judgments, that the investigation of the single concepts which the fundamental propositions contain will throw light on the fundamental propositions themselves. Advancing clarity becomes possible at all only by our investigating and determining, with express consciousness, the concepts contained in our judgments, just as on the other side we investigate and determine the kind of connection that is asserted in the judgments between the concepts. The two investigations supplement one another. Advancing clarity in the determination of concepts is the condition for advancing clarity in the understanding of the judgments into which the concepts enter, and conversely. Whether one lays the greatest weight on the one or the other investigation will depend on the special task one sets oneself. But for a complete reckoning neither of the two standpoints can be dispensed with. To this it comes in addition that the type of thought is the same in concepts as in judgments. The judgment is a connection of concepts, but the concept is a connection of marks. It is the same fundamental property of our thinking that expresses itself in both places, in the concept more as structure, in the judgment more as function.

Whereas by keeping merely to science's first presuppositions one arrives at an uncompromising theory of postulates, which places all scientific thought-work in a distant relation, or even in sharp opposition, to all other spiritual work, one will, by investigating the fundamental concepts as well, be able to be led to an understanding of the relation of scientific thought-work to the life of the spirit as a whole. And since it is precisely one of philosophy's tasks to investigate this relation, it will be of importance to attempt a

determination of the position of the doctrine of categories within philosophy.

2. When does science begin? And how does scientific consciousness stand to the thought-life that unfolds before and alongside the scientific, in greater or less independence of it?

For the elucidation of these questions it must first be held fast that a common type makes itself felt in all human thought-life, the prescientific, the scientific and the unscientific alike.

Practical life itself, its necessities and its tasks, leads to thinking. In order that a man may attain the ends he strives after, there are certain means that must be procured. Here man learns in fact and in practice what necessity is, that is, he learns to know the inexorable relation between ground and consequent. So long as he holds fast to the end, so long must he also concede the necessity of means, and finally of certain determinate means; and he learns conversely to see that the attainment of the end is a consequence of the application of certain means. He learns besides that when the same necessities and the same outer conditions repeat themselves, the same means must be resorted to. A Central Australian, for example, gathers plants, threshes them with a stick, sifts the seed, roasts it, crushes it on stones and eats it: a series of actions which, every time he is hungry, must be performed in the same way and in the same order. At bottom, science's first presuppositions may be said to be present already in this series-formation.

In the most recent time particular weight has been laid on the influence of social life on the first development of thinking. In the tribe's division into different groups or classes there lay a model for all classification, and thereby for all logic. We still speak, after all, of genera and families in the division of natural objects, in spite of the fact that eager theorists of heredity find false analogies here. The representation of time and the division of time received their development through the rhythmical course and regular recurrence of religious feasts and ceremonies. Our almanac still indicates the scheme of the church year. And religious worship demanded that liturgical acts be performed in a quite determinate manner, the same in every single case, if the result was to be attained. Here, then, was inculcated the proposition that like must be produced by like. The division of space received its clarity by reason of the religious significance of the different directions and the different places.¹

¹ÉMILE DURKHEIM has, especially in his work *Les formes élémentaires de la vie religieuse* (1912), made

That the social conditions under which men develop exercise a very great influence on their way of thinking and their forms of thought is beyond doubt, even if not everything can be explained along this road. Social influence is constantly broken against the practical experience individuals can make on their own account, face to face with those conditions of life which also gain influence on the conduct of society as a whole.

Whether one will now lay the greatest weight on individuals' practical experiences or on the influence of social institutions, it is a fact that at each given time and among each single people there appears a certain conception of the world, involuntarily and in part unconsciously developed, which is built after the same main forms as those that appear in a more stringent and special manner in scientific thinking. It bears witness to a need and a capacity to order and interpret observations and traditions and thereby to bring them into a certain connection. The thought-work that is done here proceeds without clear consciousness. No attention is directed to the single transitions of thought or to the warrant for connecting, in a certain determinate way, the single elements that observation and tradition offer. To use the terminology I have employed elsewhere: it is not analytic and synthetic intuition, but practical and concrete intuition, that is present here.² So-called sound common sense operates throughout with these last-named kinds of intuition. Through them it can, to use MEYERSON's expression,³ give "a first, very clumsy sketch of a scientific and metaphysical system". — In language, in the words language forms and the word-combinations it shapes, such a system is already contained, one that constantly makes its influence felt on the scientific forms of thought.

The origin and development of science, as the history of science shows it to us, really makes the question of its first beginning fall away entirely, since it turns out that its first germ is present as soon as men begin to think. At all stages and under all conditions a certain opposition makes itself felt between something given, something presented, and its interpretation, between the single subject-matter and the connection into which it is fitted. Progress consists in there coming to be an ever closer and stricter relation between observation and interpretation. More and more one becomes conscious that all

this way of looking at the matter prevail and sharpened it into the assertion that all categories are of religious-social origin. Cf. my treatise *Sociologi og Religionsfilosofi* (Vor Tid, 1914–15), (in French in *Revue de la Métaphysique et de Morale*, Nov. 1914).

²See *Om Begrebet Intuition* (Vid. Selsk. Oversigt 1914), p. 77.

³MEYERSON has discussed the concept of *sens commun* in an excellent manner in his book *Identité et Réalité* (1908), Chap. XI.

interpretation must in the end itself be fetched from observations, and that the fitting of the single subject-matter as a member into a whole connection must take place after exact testing both of the single observation itself and of the other observations with which it is connected. As will be shown in what follows, it is here especially the difference between identity and analogy, and the limit of analogy's warrant, that one must have an eye for.

3. It is psychology's task to find the common type for all thought-life, the scientific as well as the prescientific and the unscientific.

This type can in its generality be designated as a whole-formation. Even the simplest sensations of sense show themselves to stand in connection with one another, so that the single one cannot be understood, either as regards degree of strength or as regards quality, except by being seen as a member in a whole series or group of sensations. The temporal relation between the different sensations is already decisive for the degree of independence with which they appear. To this it comes in addition that reproductions of earlier sensations unite themselves more or less closely with the newly emerging sensations, often from the very hour of their birth. Thereby recognition, partial perception and sense-illusion become possible. Where the reproduced elements gain the decided upper hand, memory and imagination appear as a whole-formation of a higher order. Through association, displacement and comparison, intuitions of sense, of memory and of imagination can undergo alterations, articulations, without the character of intuitability disappearing. Cooperating in all these whole-formations, from first to last, are practical motives, need and impulse, pleasure and displeasure.

Characteristic of the whole-formations here spoken of (which lead to what I have called concrete and practical intuition) is the involuntary manner in which they come to be. From this follows the self-evidence and originality they seem to possess. The elements of which they are built up are not themselves accessible to us in the same way as the elements out of which we form concepts, judgments and inferences with full consciousness, since the marks of the concept, the members of the judgment and the premises of the inference are then given in advance of the new whole-formations into which they enter. Thereby what I have called analytic and synthetic intuition stands in opposition to concrete and practical intuition. Now it is in fact not all concepts, judgments and inferences that we form with full consciousness; they can also arise by involuntary whole-formation. But if concepts, judgments and inferences are to have

scientific significance, they must be capable of being formed anew, in such a way that full and clear consciousness is present at each single transition from thought to thought (analytic intuition) as well as at each single connection of thought with thought (synthetic intuition). Yet even in the involuntary formation of concepts, judgments and inferences, reflection appears as something different from immediate intuiting (in sensation, memory and imagination), inasmuch as a more or less distinct transition and comparison takes place between the elements that are brought into connection, whereas the elements out of which immediate intuitions are formed can be traced only indirectly and in part by the road of analogy.

Since the formation of concepts takes place by judging, and since the inference is the formation of a judgment out of other judgments, we can in this connection keep to the judgments.

The judgment is formed in the first instance on the basis of immediate intuiting. It states a determinate relation between elements in the content of the intuition, elements which in the intuition itself stand in continuous connection or are perhaps even fused with one another. The judgment “the table is square” is formed on the basis of an intuiting in which the property “square” was already contained (“lay”), but without being specially brought forward and without being placed in relation to the table as a whole, that is, as the sum-total of all its properties.

But why are judgments formed at all, — why do we not remain at intuiting? It is surely not, as some authors seem to conceive the matter, a kind of fall into sin that has taken place here. It is the richness and manifoldness of observation, and memory’s attempt to span this richness, that make another kind of whole-formation than immediate intuiting necessary. The primary form of the whole is burst open, and a new one is sought.

It can be difficult to draw a sharp boundary between intuition and judgment. As already indicated, the intuition can be altered, articulated. This happens by single parts pushing themselves into the foreground while others recede. In the case of the table, for example, the colour can make itself specially felt in preference to the figure, and in the figure itself the contour in preference to the form of the surface.⁴ Such displacements go on unceasingly in our sensations, memories and imaginings. But a judgment is formed only when we become conscious of these transitions instead of being wholly absorbed

⁴Cf. EDGAR RUBIN: *Synsoplevede Figurer*.

in the intuitions that are present in the single moments and that succeed one another. Now as regards this consciousness there may indeed be many transitions and degrees; but the end-points nevertheless stand in characteristic opposition to one another, and it would be unwarranted to transfer to intuition everything that holds of judgment. There is only analogy between them, an analogy grounded in their being two different ways in which psychical energy, that is, the need and the capacity for whole-formation, can express itself.

The founders of the doctrine of categories, ARISTOTLE and KANT, rightly saw that the scientific fundamental forms of cognition must be findable by analysis of the judgments that are passed. What they have not seen clearly enough is that the psychical energy at work in the formation of judgment also works, under other conditions, in other whole-formations. Only through the continuity and analogy that make themselves felt between the primary whole-formation and the judgment is it understood how scientific consciousness stands in close connection with the life of consciousness as a whole and is a more special formation of it. But it is also precisely only a relation of analogy that is present, as between two examples of the same concept. Since judgments can be derived from, built upon, intuitions, one may readily say that they are “contained” in them or “lie” in them. But that is figurative speech. For because a judgment is logically possible, it is not thereby said that it is psychologically possible; and in any case it is a conversion into another form that takes place in the transition from intuition to judgment, a transition that presupposes certain determinate conditions. One must not confuse the immediate and involuntary security with which the mind rests in intuitions of sense and of memory with the assurance that is first the work of reflection. Such a confusion is committed by HEINRICH MAIER⁵ when he declares: “Elementary judgments lie in every observation, every memory-image, every cognitive representation of imagination, in so far as all these representations have real objects, real events, states, things and so forth for their object”. And when he adds: “The alleged images of observation, memory and imagination, which are supposed to be indifferent to the opposition between true and false, valid and invalid, are fictions that never and nowhere are real”, — then I can only agree with him in so far as that immediate security cannot be called indifference. Strictly speaking one can speak of

⁵*Psychologie des emotionalen Denkens* (1908), p. 2. — Cf. on this whole question *Den menneskelige Tanke*, p. 53–59; 74 f.; 99–103.

indifference only where both members of the opposition are known and stand as equally valid. But this acquaintance is not present from the first. There has not yet been any eating of the tree of knowledge. No doubt has yet stirred; the state is positive through and through. When the immediate security is broken through contradiction, or through the demands for closer determination that new observations make, then reflection begins its work of producing new whole-formations, and then the judgment can replace the intuition. Only then does application arise for the concepts true and false as opposites.

4. The difference between elementary, involuntary thought-work and scientific thought-work can be elucidated from three different sides.

a. Reflection will first of all seek to order the different subject-matters it distinguishes according to their mutual relation. Relation, determinateness by relation, is therefore (as the history of the doctrine of categories also shows) the most conspicuous category. But orderings determined by relation can be of different significance for the development of cognition. Through a series of stages reflection advances from purely external orderings, which cannot lead further, to orderings that make it possible to derive new relations from those already present. There is a whole series of stages from chaos to rationality, and rationality can itself have different degrees. These stages are elucidated by the series that can be formed by the ordering of the subject-matters. A survey of these series I have given in “Den menneskelige Tanke” (p. 162–207); but I come back to them here in all brevity and from a somewhat different point of view.⁶

α. If we try to think for ourselves the conditions most unfavourable for human thinking, we stand before the logically irrational. We stand before such a relation between given subject-matters that they are all equally different from one another, and that they can therefore be placed in any order whatever. One may push out any member whatever without the relation between the remaining members being altered, and without anything following from it at all. Such a series I have called a chaotic difference-series. It does not appear in immediate observation. For already, purely psychologically, the order of the addends is not a matter of indifference. Our mental states are determined, both as regards degree and as regards quality, by their place in the series of our lived experiences. But there can be all possible approximations to such a logical irrationality, which differs from

⁶As an appendix to the present treatise there is printed a list of the categories, essentially as I have presented them in the book named. And there are also set out the different series-formations that express the transition from prescientific to scientific consciousness.

mathematical irrationality in this, that it cannot, as the latter can by its very manner of coming to be, lead to a reduction of the differences. We know that $\sqrt{2}$ lies in the series of numbers between 1 and 2 and nowhere else, and within the interval named the place can be determined ever more exactly the more decimals we calculate. The logically irrational, by contrast, means a halt.

The next step is that series are formed whose members lie fast, while the relations of difference vary from member to member. Such an indeterminately varying difference-series does not permit elimination without the members between which the elimination takes place coming into another relation to one another than before. But the advance consists in this, that clear survey has replaced the chaotic unrest.

A new advance is made when the differences between the members vary in a determinate direction within the series. Such a regularly varying difference-series makes possible for reflection the formation of a law or rule by which the place of the subject-matters in the series can be determined. And the task can be set of finding new members in the series, intermediate members between those already given.

If the difference between members that have their determinate place in a series is constantly the same, member for member, we get an identically varying difference-series. The concept of identity begins to dawn, provisionally as identity of the difference between qualitatively varying subject-matters. Such series can be formed of moments, numbers, degrees and places. Every moment, with its peculiar lived experience, has a determinate place in the series of moments, and every moment stands in the same relation to the preceding and to the following moment. So too with the numbers. Every number has from the first, as POINCARÉ has expressed it, its own individuality, is qualitatively different from other numbers, not merely by its place in the number-series. That one can by different roads come to the same individual number is a discovery that presupposes a higher stage than the one we here stand at. GOETHE held that mathematics moves in nothing but identities, because $2 + 2 = 4$, but also $4 = 2 + 2$, so that we get nothing other than what we had beforehand. But the different roads by which one can come to a number (e.g. by counting to 4 or by adding 2 and 2 together) are different operations, of which one discovers only afterwards that they lead to the same result and presuppose the same principles. The number is provisionally an ordinal number, a numeral. Differences of degree too are immediately differences of quality, and yet they lie in a determinate order

in a series whose members can vary in an identical manner. So it stands with places in space as well. Even if they are perhaps still regarded as qualitatively different, it is an identical varying by which one passes from place to place.

β. In the series so far spoken of, the members are qualitatively different, and it is merely a question of their mutual relation with respect to place in a series. It is a great advance when this place becomes quite determinate. Classification and comparison become possible thereby. But these operations can really be carried out only when series can be formed in which every member is comprised in the preceding one. This can again appear in two ways. In a progressive difference-series every member can, for example, be a part of the preceding. In a classification the species is a part of the genus, and the individual a part of the species. From this it can be inferred that when an individual *A* belongs to the species *B*, and the species *B* to the genus *C*, *A* also belongs to *C*. It is essentially on this that the Aristotelian doctrine of inference builds. In a partial identity-series the following member stands to the preceding as predicate to subject, or as consequent to ground. Here too classification can be used as an example, for that *A* belongs to the species *B* means that the predicates *B* designates belong to *A*. In both the series named, the inference takes place by the elimination of intermediate members.

When a series in which the members lie fast is symmetrical, that is, can be read backwards just as well as forwards, one can infer from it to the reversed series.

γ. Progressive difference-series, partial identity-series and symmetrical series may be called rational series, inasmuch as they make inference possible. But the qualitative difference of the members is not abolished by their being capable of being seen as parts or wholes, or as subjects and predicates in relation to one another. The most perfect kind of inference becomes possible only when not merely the relation between the members is constantly identical, but the members themselves are so too, so that not merely members can be pushed out, but every member can be substituted for every other. We then get an absolute identity-series: $A = B = C = D \dots$ Here is given, as LEIBNIZ first rightly saw, the foundation — and at the same time the ideal — for all rational thinking. Such a series designates the complete opposite of the chaotic difference-series. The two series designate the ideal limits between which human cognition moves.

Step by step we thus come, by running through the stages the different series designate, up to the presuppositions on which strict science rests. But we see at the same time that

the rational series are not the only possible ones, and that within the rational series a distinction must be made between those that make merely classification and comparison possible and those that make inference in the strictest sense possible. The different series form a scale, and it will perhaps be possible to find still more stages on this scale than have been named in the foregoing. The thought-work that is directed to the abolition of the chaotic relation between the subject-matters presents a whole series of degrees, until the purely rational stage is reached, where not merely the relation of the members but the members themselves are identical. This highest stage stands, however, always only as an ideal that can be reached only approximately and by abstracting from a quantity of actually present differences. Through ordering, classification and comparison, scientific consciousness works its way up towards its highest form, everywhere that the subject-matters make it possible.

KANT took account, in “*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*”, only of the highest stage of science, that is, of the stage where it was possible to draw inferences on the basis of absolute identity. Classifying and comparing science he took no account of; that he reckoned to mere empiricism. And against the objection that classification and comparison nevertheless presuppose the validity of logical thinking no less than mathematical natural science does, he answers that the principles of pure logic are indeed negative criteria of truth, but not sufficient to ground the kind of science whose possibility he wishes to investigate.⁷ But we do after all ascribe objective validity to our classifications and comparisons, just as much as to the natural laws proper, and there is therefore just as much ground for investigating the warrant for assuming the objective validity of purely logical principles as there is for investigating the objective validity of the mathematical principles and of the principle of causality. SALOMON MAIMON already saw this, in maintaining against KANT that the logical fundamental forms, affirmation and negation, have no significance if they are not presupposed valid for the subject-matters to which they are applied. Whereas KANT lets epistemology (“transcendental philosophy”) presuppose formal logic as a discipline finished once and for all, MAIMON maintains that epistemology must precede formal logic if the latter is to have real significance.⁸ — KANT naturally had the right to limit the scope of his investigations, but he had not the right to think that he

⁷*Kritik der reinen Vernunft*¹, p. 151 f.

⁸*Versuch einer neuen Logik oder Theorie des Denkens*, Berlin 1794, p. 404–408.

had thereby also limited the scope of science.

b. From a new side the transition from elementary, prescientific consciousness to scientific consciousness comes forward when we bring out a presupposition on which all the kind of series-formation spoken of in the foregoing rests. We have in the foregoing taken account only of the struggle against the differences, and have seen how the degrees of likeness, both as regards relation and as regards members, step by step approach pure identity. But all difference and likeness, and thereby all series-formation, presupposes the possibility that subject-matters can be gathered, comprehended and ordered. Here the concept of synthesis comes forward as a presupposition that holds both for formal and for real science, both for classification and for the cognition of laws. Series-formation rests on determinate relations between the subject-matters being exhibited, and relation is thought only when the members between which the relation holds are the object of one and the same act of thought. Relation presupposes synthesis. But since synthesis, gathering-together, consists precisely in bringing subject-matters into some relation or other to one another, relation and synthesis are correlative concepts.⁹

Now the series spoken of in the foregoing are only typical examples of what can find application in many special cases. Many different classifications can be undertaken, many different comparative points of view adopted, many different laws found. But all these must again be brought into connection with one another, and hereby new series-formations will come forward. Syntheses of a higher order are then presupposed than in the single series taken each by itself. What matters then is that the scope of the synthesis becomes as great as possible. A striving towards an ideal maximum makes itself felt here. There will here be greater resistance to overcome than in the single series, since the difference between the series that can be formed in the different domains will be greater than the difference between members in the same series and in the same domain. The question becomes finally whether our thinking has at its disposal logical forms for complete gathering-together, or whether at a certain point more or less bold and more or less poetic analogies do not replace logical thinking. In the sixth chapter of the present treatise we shall return to this question. But before that boundary is reached where thinking passes over into poetry, there is still a domain in which scientific hypotheses

⁹In *Den menneskelige Tanke* p. 155 f. I set up synthesis as the first category, relation as the second. An acute reader has drawn my attention to the fact that they ought to have been set up as correlative concepts, like continuity and discontinuity, likeness and difference.

move with full right. The need for gathering-together will constantly make itself felt, not merely towards subject-matters, but also towards series. And by attempts at an ever more comprehensive synthesis light can be thrown on the single series and the single subject-matters, just as the single subject-matters are already illuminated by the place they occupy in the series of which they are members. Synthesis and analysis (and analogously: continuity and discontinuity, likeness and difference) stand in constant reciprocal action with one another, and science's rhythmical oscillations find their natural explanation in this fundamental law of human thought.

c. A third point of view for characterizing the difference between prescientific and scientific thinking is given in this, that the more science develops, the greater the differentiation of the different problems that takes place. In involuntary thinking no distinction is made between subject-matter, form and value. One does not make critically clear to oneself where the boundary lies between the immediately given (the subject-matter) and the thought-elaboration one applies in interpreting it. Nor is it recognized how even the subject-matter's first appearance for us is conditioned by our receptivity, which is never absolutely passive. Neither is value definitely separated from subject-matter and form. The point of view of value will under primitive conditions have been the predominant one, since subject-matters are noticed especially on account of their practical significance, and since the way in which the subject-matter is interpreted is also conditioned by its connection with practical interests. BERGSON ought therefore to have reckoned the element of value among "les données immédiates"; he has attempted to eliminate the element of form and thinks that if it could be separated out, the element of subject-matter alone would remain. He is even inclined to think that the ground for the predominance of the element of form in science must be sought in practical considerations. But interest cooperates already in the choice of subject-matter. Naturally it cooperates also in the primitive interpretation. The teleological point of view rules in animism under all its forms, from fetishism right up into the most sublime theology. And in the primitive forms or intimations of what we now call categories it can be traced that practical motives have cooperated in their arising. Space means at first distance from an end striven after, time a relation between a wished-for future and an unsatisfying present, and the causal relation makes itself felt in the attempt to abolish these distances in space and time. In the course of science's development a constant striving is traceable to eliminate the element of value,

to abstract from all interest with the exception of the intellectual interest, which both as motive and as effect is bound in the most intimate way to thought-work itself. Thereby other values do not necessarily fall away, but the concept of value can now become the object of a special problem, which among other things also discusses the relation between intellectual value and other values.

The distinction between the three elements marks an important advance. It has not yet been strictly carried through in science, and still less in ordinary consciousness. This distinction naturally solves no problems. On the contrary, it is the condition for problems being able to be set sharply and determinately, and the very clash between the three elements sets in the end the greatest problem of all. — For the rest, this point of view, drawn from differentiation, leads back to the preceding points of view, inasmuch as with increasing differentiation increasing demands are made on synthesis, if the unity of the life of the spirit is to be preserved, and inasmuch as differentiation occasions new relations.

Chapter II

The Concept of Totality and the Fundamental Categories

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